The Dimensionless Vacuum: Recovering the Schrödinger Equation from Scale-Invariant Graph Topology*

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We demonstrate that the continuous Schrödinger equation for the hydrogen atom is mathematically equivalent to the Laplace-Beltrami operator on the unit three-sphere S^3 via Fock's stereographic projection, and that the GeoVac discrete graph Laplacian converges to this same operator in the continuum limit. This establishes a precise mathematical correspondence between the discrete graph formulation and wave mechanics. The discrete paraboloid lattice—whose nodes encode quantum numbers (n, l, m) and whose edges encode transition amplitudes—possesses a continuum limit that is conformally equivalent to the unit S^3. The dimensionless topology produces pure integer eigenvalues $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ with no intrinsic physical scale. The familiar Rydberg energy levels $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ emerge only upon imposing an energy-shell constraint $p_0^2 = -2E$ that acts as a "stereographic focal length," projecting the curved topological information into flat $\mathbb{R}^3$ observational coordinates. We verify these claims through 18 independent symbolic proofs confirming the algebraic geometry of the projection, the operator equivalence under conformal rescaling, and the eigenvalue-to-energy mapping.

I. INTRODUCTION

The Schrödinger equation is the foundation of nonrelativistic quantum mechanics. In atomic units ($\hbar = m_e = e = 1$), the time-independent equation for hydrogen reads

$$\left(-\frac{1}{2}\nabla^2 - \frac{1}{r}\right)\psi(\mathbf{r}) = E\,\psi(\mathbf{r}). \tag{1}$$

This equation presupposes a continuous, flat Euclidean space $\mathbb{R}^3$ and a radial Coulomb potential $V(r) = -1/r$ with explicit physical dimensions. These assumptions are so deeply embedded in the formalism that they are rarely questioned: continuous space provides the arena, the Coulomb potential provides the dynamics, and the quantized energy levels $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ emerge as boundary-condition eigenvalues.

Yet a remarkable observation, first made by Fock in 1935 [1], suggests a fundamentally different perspective. Fock showed that when hydrogen is analyzed in momentum space, the Schrödinger equation acquires an unexpected geometric structure. The momentum-space integral equation, with its $1/|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2$ kernel (the Fourier transform of the Coulomb potential), can be mapped by stereographic projection onto the three-sphere S^3. On S^3, the Coulomb problem reduces to a *free particle*: the eigenfunctions become hyperspherical harmonics, and the spectrum is determined by the topology of the sphere alone. The $1/r$ potential is not fundamental—it is a projection artifact of curved geometry viewed in flat coordinates.

This observation was developed further by Bargmann [2], who connected the hidden $SO(4)$ symmetry of hydrogen to the isometry group of S^3, and by Barut and Kleinert [3], who extended the symmetry to the full conformal group $SO(4, 2)$. The mathematical structure has been thoroughly studied in the context of dynamical symmetry groups [4, 5]. However, these results are typically presented as mathematical curiosities—elegant reformulations of a solved problem—rather than as evidence for a deeper physical ontology.

In this paper, we take the opposite stance. We argue that the S^3 representation is not merely a convenient mathematical trick, but reveals deep structural content that can be exploited computationally. Our starting point is the GeoVac framework [6, 7], which models the hydrogen atom as a discrete graph: nodes represent quantum states $|n, l, m\rangle$, edges represent physical transitions, and the Hamiltonian is a sparse matrix encoding connectivity. This discrete lattice is *intrinsically dimensionless*—it is a pure combinatorial topology with no inherent length, time, or energy scales.

The central result of this paper is a rigorous demonstration that:

1. The continuum limit of this discrete graph is conformally equivalent to the *unit* S^3, regardless of any physical parameters.

2. The Laplace-Beltrami operator on this unit sphere produces pure integer eigenvalues $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$, carrying no physical dimensions.

3. The dimensionful Rydberg spectrum $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ is introduced exclusively through the energy-shell constraint $p_0^2 = -2E$, which serves as a projection parameter mapping S^3 coordinates to flat $\mathbb{R}^3$ coordinates.

These claims are supported by a suite of 18 independent symbolic proofs, implemented in `sympy` and verified computationally, that confirm every algebraic step of the conformal transformation chain.

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The structure of this paper is as follows. Section III describes the dimensionless graph topology and its relationship to S^3. Section IV details the stereographic projection and the role of the conformal factor. Section V demonstrates the operator equivalence between the curved Laplacian and the flat Schrödinger equation. Section VI derives the two-electron repulsion integral as a density-overlap integral on S^3. Section VIII discusses the physical and philosophical implications.

II. WHAT IS NEW VS. WHAT IS KNOWN

The S^3 structure of the hydrogen atom has a distinguished history, and we emphasize what is established mathematics versus what is new in this work.

A. Known Results (Prior Work)

The following results are well-established in the mathematical physics literature:

- *Fock (1935)* [1]: The hydrogen atom in momentum space maps to S^3 via stereographic projection. The Coulomb problem becomes a free particle on the sphere, with the $1/r$ potential emerging from the chordal distance identity.
- *Bargmann (1936)* [2]: The hidden $SO(4)$ symmetry of hydrogen corresponds to the isometry group of S^3. The integer spectrum $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ follows from the representation theory of $SO(4)$.
- *Barut and Kleinert (1967)* [3]: The full conformal group $SO(4, 2)$ acts as the dynamical symmetry group of hydrogen, connecting S^3 to the non-compact spectrum-generating algebra.

The stereographic projection formulas (Eqs. 7–8), the unit sphere constraint (Eq. 9), the chordal distance identity (Eq. 14), the conformal Laplacian relation (Eq. 17), and the integer eigenvalue spectrum (Eq. 26) are all known results. Our symbolic proofs in the Appendix verify these identities; they do not claim to derive them for the first time.

B. New Contributions of This Work

The following are the specific new contributions:

1. **Discrete graph convergence.** We demonstrate that the GeoVac discrete paraboloid lattice—with nodes (n, l, m) and edges generated by $L_\pm, T_\pm$ operators—converges in the continuum limit to the Laplace-Beltrami operator on unit S^3. This connects a concrete computational framework (sparse graph eigenvalue problems) to the known continuous structure.
2. **Explicit symbolic verification.** The 18 symbolic proofs (Appendix A) provide a complete, machine-verified algebraic audit of the conformal transformation chain. While the underlying identities are known, this systematic verification in `sympy` is new and provides a reproducible computational check.
3. **Scale-invariance framing.** We articulate the "dimensionless vacuum" perspective: the observation that the conformal factor Ω always produces the *unit* S^3 regardless of p_0, and that all physical dimensions enter exclusively through the energy-shell constraint. While implicit in Fock's original treatment, this framing—and its implications for the GeoVac computational approach—has not been stated explicitly in the literature.
4. **Computational methodology.** The practical consequence: replacing continuous integration with sparse graph Laplacian eigenvalue problems that achieve $O(V)$ scaling, justified by the mathematical equivalence established here.

III. THE DIMENSIONLESS GRAPH

A. The Paraboloid Lattice

The GeoVac framework represents the single-electron hydrogen atom as a finite directed graph $\mathcal{G} = (V, E)$. The vertex set V consists of all quantum states $|n, l, m\rangle$ with $1 \le n \le n_{\max}$, $0 \le l < n$, and $-l \le m \le l$, giving $|V| = \sum_{n=1}^{n_{\max}} n^2$ nodes. The edge set E is generated by four transition operators:

$$L_\pm |n, l, m\rangle \propto |n, l, m \pm 1\rangle, \tag{2}$$

$$T_\pm |n, l, m\rangle \propto |n \pm 1, l, m\rangle. \tag{3}$$

These operators form the algebraic skeleton of the $SU(2) \otimes SU(1, 1)$ dynamical symmetry group, which is the maximal compact $\times$ non-compact factorization of the hydrogen conformal group $SO(4, 2)$ [3].

The graph Laplacian is defined as

$$L = D - A, \tag{4}$$

where A_{ij} is the weighted adjacency matrix constructed from the transition operators and D is the diagonal degree matrix with entries $D_{ii} = \sum_j |A_{ij}|$. The single-particle Hamiltonian is

$$H = \kappa\, L = \kappa(D - A), \tag{5}$$

where $\kappa = -1/16$ is the universal kinetic scale—the unique constant that maps the dimensionless graph eigenvalues to the physical hydrogen spectrum, consistent with the information-theoretic packing constraints of [6].

B. Intrinsic Dimensionlessness

A crucial observation about the graph $\mathcal{G}$ is that it carries *no intrinsic physical scale*. The quantum numbers (n, l, m) are pure integers. The edge weights $w_{ij} \propto 1/(n_i n_j)$ are dimensionless ratios. The graph Laplacian L is a dimensionless matrix. The only dimensionful quantity in Eq. (5) is the kinetic scale κ, which converts the dimensionless graph eigenvalues into physical energy units. But κ is an *external* parameter imposed at the measurement stage—it is not encoded in the graph topology itself.

This dimensionlessness is not accidental. It is a direct consequence of the graph's structure as a discrete analog of the unit three-sphere. To see this, we examine the continuum limit.

C. The Continuum Limit: Unit S^3

The graph $\mathcal{G}$ is a finite lattice truncation of a manifold. As $n_{\max} \to \infty$, the discrete graph Laplacian L converges to the continuous Laplace-Beltrami operator Δ_{S^3} on a three-dimensional manifold. We identify this manifold by examining the spectral convergence.

At finite $n_{\max}$, the graph Laplacian exhibits discretization artifacts: the $2s/2p$ degeneracy is broken by approximately 16% at $n_{\max} = 10$, due to differential connectivity between pole ($l = 0$) and equatorial ($l > 0$) nodes [7]. However, this splitting oscillates and decays systematically:

$$\Delta E_{2s\text{-}2p}(n_{\max}) \to 0 \quad \text{as} \quad n_{\max} \to \infty, \tag{6}$$

recovering the exact Coulomb degeneracy at a rate consistent with spectral aliasing on a compact manifold. At $n_{\max} = 30$, the splitting has decayed to less than 0.01%.

The recovered degeneracy is the hallmark of $SO(4)$ symmetry—the isometry group of S^3. The graph, in its continuum limit, therefore converges to a manifold with $SO(4)$ isometry, which uniquely identifies it as S^3 (up to discrete quotients).

The critical question is: what is the *radius* of this sphere? As we shall demonstrate in Section IV, the answer is unambiguous: the intrinsic geometry is always that of the *unit* S^3, regardless of any physical parameters. This is the mathematical content of scale invariance.

IV. THE CONFORMAL LENS: STEREOGRAPHIC PROJECTION

A. Fock's Mapping

Fock's 1935 insight was to map three-dimensional flat momentum space $\mathbb{R}^3$ onto the unit three-sphere $S^3 \subset \mathbb{R}^4$ via stereographic projection [1]. Given a momentum vector $\mathbf{p} = (p_1, p_2, p_3)$ and an energy-shell parameter p_0 (defined below), the projection is:

$$n_i = \frac{2p_0\, p_i}{p^2 + p_0^2}, \quad i = 1, 2, 3, \tag{7}$$

$$n_4 = \frac{p^2 - p_0^2}{p^2 + p_0^2}, \tag{8}$$

where $p^2 = p_1^2 + p_2^2 + p_3^2$. This map sends the origin $\mathbf{p} = 0$ to the south pole $(0, 0, 0, -1)$ and the point at infinity $|\mathbf{p}| \to \infty$ to the north pole $(0, 0, 0, +1)$, thereby compactifying $\mathbb{R}^3$ into S^3.

B. The Unit Sphere Constraint

A direct algebraic computation confirms that the image lies on the unit sphere:

$$\sum_{i=1}^{4} n_i^2 = \frac{4p_0^2 p^2 + (p^2 - p_0^2)^2}{(p^2 + p_0^2)^2} = 1. \tag{9}$$

This identity holds for *all* values of $p_0 > 0$. The parameter p_0 does not change the target manifold; it only changes which point in $\mathbb{R}^3$ maps to the south pole. This is our first key result:

The stereographic projection always produces the unit S^3, regardless of p_0. The intrinsic geometry of the target manifold has no physical scale.

To make this explicit, define the conformal factor

$$\Omega(\mathbf{p}) = \frac{2p_0}{p^2 + p_0^2}. \tag{10}$$

The spatial components of the projection satisfy the identity

$$n_i = \Omega \cdot p_i, \quad i = 1, 2, 3, \tag{11}$$

confirming that Ω is the local scale factor of the map. Under the substitution $u = p/p_0$ (dimensionless momentum), the conformal factor becomes

$$\Omega = \frac{2}{p_0(1 + u^2)}, \tag{12}$$

and the induced metric on S^3, expressed in flat stereographic coordinates, takes the form

$$\mathrm{d}s_{S^3}^2 = \Omega^2\, \mathrm{d}p^2 = \frac{4}{(1 + u^2)^2}\, \mathrm{d}u^2. \tag{13}$$

This is the standard round metric on the unit S^3 in stereographic coordinates. The factors of p_0 cancel identically, confirming that the intrinsic geometry is scale-invariant.

C. The Chordal Distance Identity

The conformal structure of the projection is captured by a fundamental distance identity. For two momentum vectors $\mathbf{p}$ and $\mathbf{q}$ with images $\mathbf{n}(\mathbf{p})$ and $\mathbf{n}(\mathbf{q})$ on S^3:

$$|\mathbf{n}(\mathbf{p}) - \mathbf{n}(\mathbf{q})|^2 = \Omega(\mathbf{p})\,\Omega(\mathbf{q})\,|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{q}|^2. \tag{14}$$

The left side is the chordal (Euclidean 4D) distance on S^3; the right side is the flat Euclidean distance in $\mathbb{R}^3$, weighted by conformal factors at both endpoints.

This identity is the algebraic engine behind the emergence of the Coulomb potential. The momentum-space Schrödinger equation contains the kernel $1/|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2$, which is the Fourier transform of the $1/r$ Coulomb potential. Under Fock's projection, Eq. (14) converts this kernel into $1/|\mathbf{n} - \mathbf{n}'|^2$ on S^3 (up to conformal weights), transforming the interacting Coulomb problem into a *free-particle* problem on the sphere [1].

D. Physical Interpretation of p_0

What is p_0? In Fock's original treatment, it is defined by the energy-shell constraint:

$$p_0^2 = -2mE, \tag{15}$$

where $E < 0$ for bound states (we set $m = 1$ in atomic units). For the n-th energy level of hydrogen, $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$, so $p_0 = 1/n$.

Crucially, p_0 does *not* determine the curvature of the target manifold—the unit sphere constraint Eq. (9) holds for all p_0. Instead, p_0 acts as a **stereographic focal length**: it determines how the flat momentum coordinates $\mathbf{p}$ are laid out on the fixed unit sphere. Different values of p_0 correspond to different stereographic charts of the *same* underlying manifold, analogous to choosing different focal lengths for a camera lens viewing the same scene.

The conformal factor Ω encodes this projection:

- At $\mathbf{p} = 0$: $\Omega = 2/p_0$ (maximum magnification at the south pole).
- As $|\mathbf{p}| \to \infty$: $\Omega \to 0$ (the north pole is infinitely compressed).

The volume element transforms as $\mathrm{d}\Omega_{S^3} = \Omega^3\,\mathrm{d}^3p/p_0^3$, where the Jacobian Ω^3 encodes the non-uniform compression of flat space onto the sphere.

E. Inverse Projection

The map is invertible away from the north pole:

$$p_i = \frac{p_0\, n_i}{1 - n_4}, \quad i = 1, 2, 3. \tag{16}$$

This confirms the projection is a diffeomorphism $S^3 \setminus \{N\} \to \mathbb{R}^3$, where $N = (0, 0, 0, 1)$ is the north pole. The compactification of $\mathbb{R}^3$ to S^3 adjoins this single point at infinity, mirroring the Riemann sphere compactification $\mathbb{C} \cup \{\infty\} \cong S^2$ in one lower dimension.

V. OPERATOR EQUIVALENCE AND THE CONTINUUM LIMIT

A. The Conformal Laplacian Identity

Having established the geometric setting, we now demonstrate how the Laplace-Beltrami operator on S^3—the continuum limit of the graph Laplacian—relates to the flat-space Schrödinger operator.

For a conformal rescaling of the metric $g_{S^3} = \Omega^2 g_{\text{flat}}$ in $n = 3$ dimensions, the Laplace-Beltrami operators are related by

$$\Delta_{S^3} f = \Omega^{-2}\left[\Delta_{\text{flat}} f + \nabla(\ln\Omega)\cdot\nabla f\right], \tag{17}$$

where $\Delta_{\text{flat}} = \partial^2/\partial p^2 + (2/p)\,\partial/\partial p$ is the radial Laplacian in three-dimensional flat space (for the $l = 0$ sector), and the connection correction $\nabla(\ln\Omega)\cdot\nabla f$ encodes the curvature of the stereographic coordinate system.

For the conformal factor $\Omega = 2p_0/(p^2 + p_0^2)$, the logarithmic gradient is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\ln\Omega}{\mathrm{d}p} = -\frac{2p}{p^2 + p_0^2}. \tag{18}$$

This is the *connection term* that distinguishes the curved Laplacian from the flat one. It is a rational function of p—no transcendental functions appear—which is essential for clean algebraic manipulation.

B. Verification: Constants and Eigenfunctions

As a consistency check, the Laplace-Beltrami operator annihilates constants:

$$\Delta_{S^3}(1) = 0, \tag{19}$$

confirming the basic property that constants are harmonic on any Riemannian manifold.

For the first nontrivial eigenfunction, consider the hyperspherical angle χ defined by the stereographic projection $p = p_0 \tan(\chi/2)$. The function $\cos\chi$, which in stereographic coordinates takes the form

$$\cos\chi = \frac{p_0^2 - p^2}{p_0^2 + p^2}, \tag{20}$$

is the $n = 2$, $l = 0$ eigenfunction of Δ_{S^3}. Direct symbolic computation confirms

$$\Delta_{S^3}(\cos\chi) = -3\,\cos\chi. \tag{21}$$

More generally, the $l = 0$ eigenfunctions are Gegenbauer polynomials $C^1_{n-1}(\cos\chi)$:

$$C^1_0 = 1, \tag{22}$$
$$C^1_1 = 2\cos\chi, \tag{23}$$
$$C^1_2 = 4\cos^2\chi - 1, \tag{24}$$

with eigenvalues

$$\Delta_{S^3}\, C^1_{n-1}(\cos\chi) = -(n^2-1)\, C^1_{n-1}(\cos\chi). \tag{25}$$

We have verified Eq. (25) symbolically for $n = 1, 2, 3$ using the conformal Laplacian formula, confirming exact agreement.

C. The Dimensionless Spectrum

Equation (25) is the central result of this section. The eigenvalues of the Laplace-Beltrami operator on the unit S^3 are

$$\lambda_n = -(n^2-1), \quad n = 1, 2, 3, \ldots \tag{26}$$

These are *pure integers*. They carry no physical dimensions. They depend on no physical parameters—not on p_0, not on the electron mass, not on the fine structure constant. They are properties of the topology alone.

This spectrum arises from the same mechanism as the quantization of angular momentum on S^2: the compactness of the manifold forces the eigenfunctions to satisfy periodicity constraints that admit only discrete mode numbers. On S^3, these mode numbers correspond to the principal quantum number n of hydrogen.

D. The Energy Shell: Projecting to Physics

How, then, do the dimensionless hydrogen energy levels emerge from dimensionless eigenvalues? The answer lies entirely in the energy-shell constraint Eq. (15). Setting $p_0^2 = 1/n^2$ (hydrogen in atomic units), the eigenvalue equation on S^3 becomes an equation for the energy through the following algebraic chain:

1. The S^3 eigenvalue equation: $\Delta_{S^3}\,\Psi_n = -(n^2-1)\,\Psi_n$.
2. The energy-shell constraint: $p_0^2 = -2E = 1/n^2$.
3. Combine: the ratio $\lambda_n \cdot p_0^2 = -(n^2-1)/n^2 = -(1-1/n^2)$.
4. The physical energy: $E_n = -p_0^2/2 = -1/(2n^2)$.

Step 4 is simply the definition of p_0 rearranged. The Rydberg formula is *not* derived from the sphere's curvature. It is the energy-shell parameter, translated back into energy units. The integer eigenvalues λ_n supply the quantum numbers; the energy shell supplies the units.

The complete transformation chain is summarized diagrammatically:

$$\boxed{\begin{array}{c}\text{Discrete Graph } \mathcal{G}\\ \downarrow \text{ continuum limit}\\ \Delta_{S^3} \text{ on unit } S^3\\ \lambda_n = -(n^2-1) \text{ (dimensionless)}\\ \downarrow \text{ energy shell } p_0^2 = -2E\\ E_n = -\frac{1}{2n^2} \text{ (dimensionful)}\end{array}} \tag{27}$$

E. Conformal Decomposition of the Wavefunction

To complete the operator equivalence, we demonstrate that the S^3 Laplacian acting on a conformally weighted wavefunction decomposes cleanly into the momentum-space Schrödinger structure.

Define the conformally weighted wavefunction

$$\Phi(p) = \Omega^2(p)\,\varphi(p), \tag{28}$$

where $\varphi(p)$ is the physical momentum-space wavefunction. Applying Δ_{S^3} via the conformal identity Eq. (17), and expanding via the Leibniz rule, one obtains

$$\Delta_{S^3}[\Omega^2\varphi] = \sum_{k=0}^{2} a_k(p)\,\frac{\mathrm{d}^k\varphi}{\mathrm{d}p^k}, \tag{29}$$

where the coefficients $a_k(p)$ are *rational functions* of p and p_0. No transcendental or unresolved terms appear. This decomposition has been verified symbolically: the coefficient of φ'' is nonzero (confirming a second-order kinetic operator exists), and all coefficients are manifestly rational, confirming that the S^3 Laplacian acting on conformally weighted wavefunctions produces exactly the structure of a second-order differential equation in the flat momentum coordinate.

VI. TWO-ELECTRON REPULSION ON S^3

The preceding sections established that the single-electron Coulomb problem maps exactly onto the unit three-sphere S^3 via Fock's stereographic projection. We now extend this framework to the two-electron repulsion integral and derive its S^3 representation.

A. Momentum-Space Representation

The direct Coulomb integral (Slater F^0) between orbitals a and b in position space is

$$F^0(a,b) = \int_0^\infty\!\!\int_0^\infty |R_a(r_1)|^2\,|R_b(r_2)|^2\,\frac{1}{r_>}\,r_1^2\,r_2^2\,dr_1\,dr_2\,, \tag{30}$$

where $r_> = \max(r_1, r_2)$. For hydrogen-like orbitals with nuclear charge Z, exact values are known:

$$F^0(1s,1s) = \tfrac{5}{8}Z, \quad F^0(1s,2s) = \tfrac{17}{81}Z,$$
$$F^0(2s,2s) = \tfrac{77}{512}Z. \tag{31}$$

An equivalent momentum-space representation exists for s-orbital pairs. Defining the density Fourier transform

$$\tilde{\rho}_a(q) = \frac{1}{q}\int_0^\infty |R_a(r)|^2\, r\, \sin(qr)\, dr\,, \tag{32}$$

the Slater integral becomes

$$F^0(a,b) = \frac{2}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \tilde{\rho}_a(q)\,\tilde{\rho}_b(q)\, dq\,. \tag{33}$$

For the hydrogen $1s$ and $2s$ orbitals:

$$\tilde{\rho}_{1s}(q) = \frac{16Z^4}{(q^2+4Z^2)^2}\,, \tag{34}$$

$$\tilde{\rho}_{2s}(q) = \frac{Z^4(Z^4 - 3Z^2q^2 + 2q^4)}{(Z^2+q^2)^4}\,. \tag{35}$$

B. Fock Projection onto S^3

We apply the Fock stereographic projection with parameter $p_0 = 2Z$, under which $q = 2Z\tan u$ for $u \in [0, \pi/2)$ and $dq = 2Z/\cos^2 u\, du$. Define the *projected density*

$$\Phi_a(t) \equiv \tilde{\rho}_a(2Zt)\,, \tag{36}$$

where $t = \tan u = q/(2Z)$ is the dimensionless momentum transfer. Under this substitution, Eq. (33) becomes

$$\boxed{F^0(a,b) = \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \Phi_a(t)\,\Phi_b(t)\, dt} \tag{37}$$

This is the master formula: F^0 is a *single* integral over one S^3 coordinate, not a double integral over two points.

1. $1s$–$1s$ verification

Substituting $q = 2Zt$ into Eq. (34):

$$\Phi_{1s}(t) = \frac{16Z^4}{(4Z^2t^2+4Z^2)^2} = \frac{1}{(t^2+1)^2}\,. \tag{38}$$

Then

$$F^0(1s,1s) = \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \frac{dt}{(t^2+1)^4} = \frac{4Z}{\pi}\cdot\frac{5\pi}{32} = \frac{5Z}{8}\,. \quad \checkmark \tag{39}$$

In angular coordinates ($t = \tan u$, $dt = du/\cos^2 u$), the integrand becomes $\cos^6 u$, showing that the $1s$ density is *constant* on S^3 (up to the conformal Jacobian).

2. $1s$–$2s$ verification (critical test)

Substituting into Eq. (35):

$$\Phi_{2s}(t) = \frac{1 - 12t^2 + 32t^4}{(4t^2+1)^4}\,. \tag{40}$$

This is *not* constant on S^3—it has zeros at $t^2 = (3 \pm 1)/16$, corresponding to nodes in the $2s$ radial wavefunction. The integral evaluates to

$$F^0(1s,2s) = \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \frac{1-12t^2+32t^4}{(t^2+1)^2(4t^2+1)^4}\, dt$$
$$= \frac{4Z}{\pi}\cdot\frac{17\pi}{324} = \frac{17Z}{81}\,. \quad \checkmark \tag{41}$$

3. $2s$–$2s$ verification

$$F^0(2s,2s) = \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \frac{(1-12t^2+32t^4)^2}{(4t^2+1)^8}\, dt$$
$$= \frac{4Z}{\pi}\cdot\frac{77\pi}{2048} = \frac{77Z}{512}\,. \quad \checkmark \tag{42}$$

All three Slater integrals are reproduced exactly by the S^3 density-overlap formula (37).

C. Structural Result: Node Property vs. Edge Property

The key structural finding is that Eq. (37) is a *single* integral over one S^3 coordinate (the momentum transfer t), not a double integral over two independent S^3 points. Each orbital a contributes a density *function* $\Phi_a(t)$ on S^3, and V_{ee} is the weighted overlap:

$$V_{ee}(a,b) = \langle \Phi_a | \Phi_b \rangle_{S^3} \equiv \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \Phi_a(t)\,\Phi_b(t)\, dt\,. \tag{43}$$

In graph-theoretic language, V_{ee} is a **node property** (each node carries a density profile) rather than an **edge property** (a pairwise distance between node coordinates).

a. Failure of the chordal ansatz. A naive chordal-distance ansatz $V_{ee} = \kappa_{ee}/d^2_{\text{chord}}$, where $d^2 = 2(1 - \boldsymbol{\xi}_a\cdot\boldsymbol{\xi}_b)$ is the chordal distance between S^3 points assigned to each orbital, gives (with $\kappa_{ee} = 5Z/2$):

Pair	Slater F^0	κ/d^2	Ratio
$1s$–$1s$	$5Z/8$	$5Z/8$	1.00
$1s$–$2s$	$17Z/81$	$25Z/4$	29.8
$2s$–$2s$	$77Z/512$	$5Z/8$	4.2

The chordal ansatz is calibrated to reproduce $F^0(1s,1s)$ exactly (because the $1s$ density is constant on S^3, making a single point adequate), but overestimates $F^0(1s,2s)$ by a factor of 30. The fundamental reason is that the $2s$ density function has nodes and oscillations on S^3 that cannot be captured by a single coordinate point.

D. Natural Projection Scales

Each shell has a natural Fock projection scale:

$$n = 1: \quad p_0 = 2Z \qquad (\text{denominator } q^2 + 4Z^2)\,, \quad (44)$$

$$n = 2: \quad p_0 = Z \qquad (\text{denominator } q^2 + Z^2)\,. \quad (45)$$

When all orbitals are projected using a *single* $p_0 = 2Z$, the $n = 1$ density becomes the constant function $\Phi_{1s} = 1/(1+t^2)^2$, while higher-shell densities acquire polynomial modulations. These modulations encode the radial node structure and are responsible for the reduced overlap integrals ($17/81 < 5/8$).

E. Implications

The density-overlap formula (37) has three implications for the computational framework:

1. **Exact Slater integrals on S^3.** The Fock projection converts position-space double radial integrals into single rational-function integrals on S^3, which can be evaluated in closed form via partial fractions.

2. **Graph implementation.** In the graph Laplacian framework, each node (orbital state) should carry a density profile $\Phi_a(t)$, and V_{ee} matrix elements should be computed as overlap integrals rather than pairwise edge weights.

3. **Angular momentum extension.** The $1D$ monopole formula (33) applies to s-orbital pairs. For $l > 0$, the full $3D$ angular convolution is required, involving the multipole expansion of the orbital density in spherical harmonics.

VII. GENERALIZATION TO N ELECTRONS

The preceding sections established the S^3 structure for a single electron. The framework generalizes naturally to N-electron atoms: the N-body configuration space $\mathbb{R}^{3N}$ maps, via the hyperspherical Fock projection, onto the unit sphere S^{3N-1} [9].

A. The Angular Manifold and Its Isometry Group

For N electrons at positions $\boldsymbol{r}_1, \ldots, \boldsymbol{r}_N \in \mathbb{R}^3$, the hyperradius $R = \sqrt{\sum_i r_i^2}$ separates a radial coordinate from a $(3N-1)$-dimensional angular manifold. In the limit $R \to 0$ (all electrons at the nucleus), the angular dynamics reduces to the Laplace–Beltrami operator on the unit S^{3N-1}, whose isometry group is $\mathrm{SO}(3N)$.

The eigenvalues of the grand angular momentum operator Λ^2 on S^{3N-1} are the $\mathrm{SO}(3N)$ Casimir eigenvalues:

$$\mu_{\text{free}}(\nu) = \frac{\nu(\nu + 3N - 2)}{2}, \quad \nu = 0, 1, 2, \ldots \quad (46)$$

These are the "free" eigenvalues—the spectrum before any electron-electron or electron-nuclear interactions are included in the charge function C/R.

B. The Hierarchy of Spheres

Table I summarizes the angular manifold, symmetry group, and Casimir structure for the first few electron numbers. Each row represents a qualitatively different angular problem, but all share the same structural origin: the Laplace–Beltrami operator on a unit sphere of appropriate dimension.

TABLE I. Angular manifold structure for N-electron atoms. The centrifugal term $l_{\text{eff}}(l_{\text{eff}}+1)/(2R^2)$ arises from extracting the Jacobian factor $R^{-(3N-1)/2}$. The effective quantum number $n_{\text{eff}} = l_{\text{eff}} + 1$ determines the quasi-Coulomb energy.

N	S^{d-1}	$\mathrm{SO}(d)$	μ_{free}	l_{eff}	n_{eff}
1	S^2	SO(3)	$\nu(\nu+1)/2$	0	1
2	S^5	SO(6)	$\nu(\nu+4)/2$	3/2	5/2
3	S^8	SO(9)	$\nu(\nu+7)/2$	3	4
4	S^{11}	SO(12)	$\nu(\nu+10)/2$	9/2	11/2

For hydrogen ($N = 1$), S^2 recovers the familiar angular momentum eigenvalues $l(l+1)/2$ and the SO(3) rotation group, while S^3 (from the full 3D problem including the radial Fock projection) gives the SO(4) hydrogen symmetry of Section IV. For helium ($N = 2$), the angular manifold is S^5 with SO(6) symmetry, and the free eigenvalues $\nu(\nu+4)/2 = 0, 3, 8, 15, \ldots$ have been verified numerically to $< 0.001\%$ against the hyperspherical angular solver [9].

C. Fermionic Statistics and Ground-State Selection

The permutation group S_N acts on the angular manifold by exchanging electron coordinates. Fermionic antisymmetry requires the spatial wavefunction to transform under a specific irreducible representation (irrep) of S_N, determined by the spin state.

For helium ($N = 2$, singlet ^1S), the spatial part is symmetric under S_2 exchange $\alpha \to \pi/2 - \alpha$. This selects even grand angular momentum $\nu = 0, 2, 4, \ldots$, and the ground state sits at $\nu = 0$ with $\mu_{\text{free}} = 0$.

For lithium ($N = 3$, doublet ^2S), the spatial part transforms as the standard (mixed-symmetry) irrep $[2, 1]$ of S_3. This irrep first appears at $\nu = 1$, so the lowest allowed free eigenvalue is $\mu_{\text{free}} = 1 \cdot 8/2 = 4$—not zero.

The higher baseline reflects the Pauli exclusion principle encoded group-theoretically: more electrons require higher angular momentum to satisfy antisymmetry.

D. Implications for the Dimensionless Vacuum

The N-electron generalization preserves the core principle: at $R = 0$, the angular dynamics is a free particle on the unit S^{3N-1}, with pure integer-ratio eigenvalues determined by the SO($3N$) Casimir. No physical scale enters. The electron-nuclear and electron-electron interactions enter through the charge function $C(\hat{\Omega})/R$, which acts as a perturbation that lifts the Casimir degeneracy—analogous to how the energy-shell constraint $p_0^2 = -2E$ projects the dimensionless S^3 eigenvalues into dimensionful energies for the single-electron case.

The 18 symbolic proofs of Appendix A verify the $N = 1$ case. The generalization to $N > 1$ follows from the same algebraic structure: the Laplace–Beltrami operator on S^{3N-1} is the continuum limit of a discrete graph Laplacian on the N-electron angular lattice, and its spectrum is determined by the topology of the sphere alone.

VIII. DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

A. Summary of Results

We have established a rigorous mathematical chain connecting the discrete GeoVac lattice to the continuous Schrödinger equation through three exact algebraic stages:

Stage 1: Discrete → Continuous. The paraboloid lattice, with n^2-dimensional shells connected by $SU(2) \otimes SU(1,1)$ transition operators, converges in the continuum limit to the Laplace-Beltrami operator on a compact manifold with $SO(4)$ isometry.

Stage 2: Curved → Flat. Fock's stereographic projection maps the unit S^3 to flat $\mathbb{R}^3$ momentum space, with conformal factor $\Omega = 2p_0/(p^2 + p_0^2)$. The chordal distance identity (Eq. 14) converts the free-particle Green's function on S^3 into the Coulomb kernel in flat space.

Stage 3: Dimensionless → Dimensionful. The energy-shell constraint $p_0^2 = -2E$ converts pure integer eigenvalues $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ into the Rydberg energy levels $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$.

Each stage has been verified by independent symbolic computation. The 18 passing tests constitute a complete algebraic audit of the conformal transformation chain, covering: the unit sphere constraint, the conformal factor identities, the projection limits, the chordal distance identity, the dot-product form, the volume Jacobian, the inverse projection, the connection term, the conformal Laplacian of Ω^2, the zero-mode annihilation, the eigenvalue equation for $n = 2$ and $n = 3$, the conformal decomposition, and the eigenvalue-to-energy mapping.

B. The Dimensionless Vacuum Hypothesis

The mathematical evidence supports a precise structural observation: *the Schrödinger equation for hydrogen is mathematically equivalent, under Fock's conformal projection, to the Laplace-Beltrami operator on a dimensionless, scale-invariant topology (unit S^3).* The continuous equation and its dimensionful energy levels can be viewed as emergent properties of projecting this topology into observational coordinates. This is a mathematical equivalence under conformal projection, not a proof of physical priority—whether the graph or the differential equation is "more fundamental" is a question of physical interpretation, not of theorem.

Three features of the projection merit emphasis:

(i) Scale invariance. The conformal factor Ω always produces the unit S^3, regardless of p_0. Substituting $u = p/p_0$ yields the standard metric $4/(1 + u^2)^2\, \mathrm{d}u^2$ with all p_0-dependence cancelled. The intrinsic geometry of the vacuum has no scale.

(ii) Integer spectrum. The eigenvalues $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ are pure integers determined by the topology of S^3. They count the number of independent oscillation modes that fit on the compact manifold, in exact analogy with standing waves on a finite string.

(iii) Energy as projection cost. The dimensionful energy $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ enters exclusively through the energy-shell constraint—the requirement that the stereographic focal length be consistent with the bound-state energy. Energy is the cost of representing curved topological information in flat coordinates.

C. Relation to the Coulomb Potential

A frequently asked question is: where does the $1/r$ Coulomb potential come from? In the standard formulation, $V(r) = -1/r$ is an input to the Schrödinger equation. In the topological formulation, it is an *output* of the conformal projection.

The mechanism is the chordal distance identity, Eq. (14). On S^3, the Green's function for the Laplace-Beltrami operator is $G(\mathbf{n}, \mathbf{n}') \propto 1/|\mathbf{n} - \mathbf{n}'|^2$, which is the natural interaction kernel on a sphere. Under stereographic projection, this becomes

$$\frac{1}{|\mathbf{n} - \mathbf{n}'|^2} = \frac{1}{\Omega(\mathbf{p})\, \Omega(\mathbf{p}')\, |\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2}, \tag{47}$$

which, when Fourier transformed to position space, yields the $1/r$ Coulomb potential (with conformal weight corrections that are absorbed into the wavefunction normalization). The Coulomb singularity at $r = 0$ corresponds to the divergence of the stereographic map at the south pole—it is a coordinate singularity of the projection, not a physical singularity of the underlying topology.

D. Implications for the Discrete Model

The results of this paper provide a formal justification for the GeoVac framework's computational approach. The fact that the continuum limit of the graph Laplacian is conformally equivalent to the unit S^3 explains several empirical observations:

Spectral exactness: The algebraic operators $T_\pm, L_\pm$ reproduce the exact Rydberg spectrum because they encode the $SO(4)$ Casimir structure of S^3.

Discretization artifacts: The s/p splitting at finite $n_{\max}$ is spectral aliasing on a compact manifold—it arises from boundary effects in the finite graph and decays as $n_{\max} \to \infty$.

Universal kinetic scale: The constant $\kappa = -1/16$ is the unique kinetic scale consistent with the Rydberg formula and the graph topology. It is not independently derived from topology alone—it is the bridge between the dimensionless graph and dimensionful physics, determined by requiring the graph eigenvalues to reproduce the hydrogen spectrum via the energy-shell projection mechanism. Its universality across all nuclear charges Z (via Z^2 scaling) confirms that the graph topology correctly encodes the *relative* spectral structure.

E. Limitations

Several caveats apply. First, the single-electron framework of Sections III–V addresses hydrogen only. Section VI extends the framework to two-electron repulsion for s-orbital pairs; the general case with angular momentum requires the full three-dimensional Fourier convolution. Second, the conformal projection presented here recovers only the non-relativistic Schrödinger equation. Relativistic corrections (fine structure, spin-orbit coupling) presumably require additional geometric structure, such as the fiber bundle construction explored in companion papers [6, 7]. Third, while the discretization artifacts of the graph Laplacian decay systematically, we have not proven a rate of convergence—only demonstrated it empirically through $n_{\max} = 30$.

F. Concluding Remarks

Vladimir Fock discovered in 1935 that the hydrogen atom, when viewed in momentum space, lives naturally on a three-sphere. We have demonstrated that this sphere is intrinsically dimensionless—a pure topology with no physical scale—and that every dimensionful quantity in the Schrödinger equation is introduced by the act of projecting this topology into flat observational coordinates. Furthermore, we have shown that the GeoVac discrete graph Laplacian converges to this same S^3 structure in the continuum limit, establishing a rigorous mathematical foundation for the sparse graph computational approach.

Within this mathematical equivalence, the wave equation can be viewed as a continuous, dimensionful projection of a discrete, dimensionless topology. The Coulomb potential emerges as the coordinate distortion created by the stereographic flattening, and the energy levels emerge from the energy-shell constraint that parameterizes the projection.

We emphasize that these are statements of mathematical equivalence, not claims about which formulation is physically prior. Whether the topological perspective points toward a deeper theory of quantum mechanics, or provides a computationally useful reformulation, is a question we leave to future investigation. What is established here is the precise mathematical chain connecting the discrete graph to the continuous equation, verified step by step through symbolic computation.

G. Extension to Molecules

The principle that the graph Laplacian should discretize the Laplace-Beltrami operator on the natural conformal manifold extends beyond single-center systems. For diatomic molecules, the two-center Coulomb problem separates in prolate spheroidal coordinates (ξ, η, φ), just as the single-center problem separates in spherical coordinates (leading to S^3 via Fock's projection). Discretizing the Laplace-Beltrami operator on the prolate spheroid yields a molecular lattice with R-dependence built into the metric—no fitted parameters are required. For H_2^+, this approach achieves $R_{\text{eq}} = 2.001$ bohr (0.21% error) and $E_{\min} = -0.598$ Ha (0.70% error) with zero free parameters [8]. This suggests a general principle: every separable quantum system has a natural lattice defined by the coordinate system in which separation occurs.

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Appendix A: Symbolic Test Suite Summary

The following 18 tests were implemented in `sympy` (Python symbolic algebra) and executed with all assertions passing. Each test verifies a specific algebraic identity in the conformal transformation chain. The tests are organized into two modules.

1. Module I: Stereographic Projection Geometry

1. **Unit sphere constraint.** $\sum_i n_i^2 = 1$ for all $\mathbf{p} \in \mathbb{R}^3$.
2. **Conformal factor identity.** $n_1^2 + n_2^2 + n_3^2 = \Omega^2 |\mathbf{p}|^2$.
3. **South pole limit.** $\mathbf{p} = 0 \Rightarrow \mathbf{n} = (0, 0, 0, -1)$.
4. **North pole limit.** $|\mathbf{p}| \to \infty \Rightarrow \mathbf{n} \to (0, 0, 0, +1)$.
5. **Conformal factor limits.** $\Omega(0) = 2/p_0$; $\Omega(\infty) = 0$.
6. **Chordal distance identity.** $|\mathbf{n} - \mathbf{n}'|^2 = \Omega\,\Omega'\,|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2$.
7. **Dot product form.** $\mathbf{n} \cdot \mathbf{n}' = 1 - \frac{1}{2}\Omega\,\Omega'\,|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2$.
8. **Volume Jacobian.** $\Omega^3 = 8p_0^3/(p^2 + p_0^2)^3$.
9. **Numerical spot-check.** All identities verified at concrete floating-point values.
10. **Inverse projection.** $p_i = p_0\, n_i/(1 - n_4)$ round-trips to the identity.

2. Module II: Conformal Laplacian and Eigenvalues

11. **Connection term.** $\mathrm{d}(\ln \Omega)/\mathrm{d}p = -2p/(p^2 + p_0^2)$.
12. **Laplacian of Ω^2.** $\Delta_{\mathrm{flat}}(\Omega^2)/\Omega^2$ is a rational function.
13. **Zero-mode annihilation.** $\Delta_{S^3}(1) = 0$.
14. $n = 2$ **eigenvalue.** $\Delta_{S^3}(\cos\chi) = -3\cos\chi$.
15. **Conformal decomposition.** $\Delta_{S^3}[\Omega^2\varphi]$ has rational coefficients in $\{\varphi, \varphi', \varphi''\}$.
16. $n = 2$ **eigenfunction.** Full eigenvalue equation verified symbolically.
17. $n = 3$ **eigenfunction.** $\Delta_{S^3}(4\cos^2\chi - 1) = -8(4\cos^2\chi - 1)$.
18. **Eigenvalue-to-energy mapping.** $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ with $p_0^2 = 1/n^2$ gives $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$.

Appendix B: Conformal Laplacian Derivation

For completeness, we derive Eq. (17). Let $\tilde{g}_{ij} = \Omega^2 g_{ij}$ be a conformally rescaled metric in n dimensions, with $\Omega = e^{\omega}$. The Christoffel symbols transform as

$$\tilde{\Gamma}^k_{ij} = \Gamma^k_{ij} + \delta^k_i\,\partial_j\omega + \delta^k_j\,\partial_i\omega - g_{ij}\,g^{kl}\,\partial_l\omega. \tag{B1}$$

The Laplace-Beltrami operator $\Delta_{\tilde{g}} f = \tilde{g}^{ij}\left(\partial_i\partial_j f - \tilde{\Gamma}^k_{ij}\,\partial_k f\right)$ yields, after substitution:

$$\Delta_{\tilde{g}} f = \Omega^{-2}\left[\Delta_g f + (n-2)\,g^{ij}\,(\partial_i\omega)(\partial_j f)\right]. \tag{B2}$$

Setting $n = 3$ and $g = g_{\mathrm{flat}}$ gives Eq. (17), with the connection correction proportional to $(n - 2) = 1$.